

Subspace.money

Product Teardown

5 Sharpest Feedbacks Across the Product Pillars

Submitted by

Sk Akash Ali

For: Product Intern Assignment, Vocallabs.ai

31 May 2026

Executive Summary

Subspace gets a lot right that most consumer fintech apps miss. The AI Powered Mailbox blocks ~99% of marketing emails and routes transactional confirmations into group chat — a quiet but real differentiator. Pre-purchase chat with the group admin builds genuine trust. UPI checkout deep-links into 10 apps with zero failures. KYC is correctly deferred until users have skin in the game. And founder Joey Dash personally replies to 1-star Play Store reviews — rare and worth noting.

The five feedbacks below are not about whether the product works. They are about the gap between what Subspace already does well and what it would take to compound that into category leadership — especially under the new CEO transition to Anupam Sharma and the company's stated AI-native strategic re-positioning.

Analytical lens: This teardown applies a SWOT view at the company level (strengths in operational AI and bootstrapped profitability; weaknesses in trust math and category sprawl) and Porter's Five Forces at the marketplace level (low buyer switching costs, high admin/supply concentration risk, and substitution pressure from informal Telegram groups). Each feedback is anchored in the pillar it most affects, with cross-pillar implications called out where relevant.

The 5 Feedbacks

#	Feedback	Pillar
1	Home screen identity sprawl confuses new users	UX / Features
2	Admin rating system has no signal — every admin looks identical	Features / Trust
3	Refund logic is a black box at the moment of payment	Features / Trust
4	"Rentals" is a marketed pillar but a phantom feature	GTM / Positioning
5	Marketing claims don't match what's on screen	GTM / Copy

Analytical Framework

Before the five feedbacks, this section summarises the lens applied: a company-level SWOT and a marketplace-level Porter's Five Forces read. The five feedbacks that follow address the highest-leverage items from the Weaknesses and Threats quadrants — those most likely to compound into churn or category loss if unaddressed under the AI-native pivot.

SWOT:

Strengths	Weaknesses
• AI Powered Mailbox blocks ~99% of marketing email; routes transactional confirmations into group chat • Bootstrapped and profitable for years (₹36.5 Cr ARR FY25) • Founder Joey Dash personally responds to 1-star Play Store reviews • UPI checkout deep-links into 10 apps with zero failures • KYC correctly deferred until skin in the game; not gated at signup	• Refund logic opaque at moment of payment — "partial refund" with no formula • Admin rating system provides no real signal — most admins display 5★ + crown • Home tab presents 6 competing CTAs; core promise of subscription-sharing invisible • Marketed three pillars (Subscriptions · Sharing · Rentals), ships effectively two • "Subspace Admin" app on Play Store flagged as unavailable for modern Android
Opportunities	Threats
• CEO transition to Anupam Sharma + AI-native repositioning opens a fresh narrative • Cross-sell from subscription buyers to rentals via partnerships (untapped) • Student demand-side (college-email perks exist, under-merchandised) • B2B subscription marketplace for SMBs (the "Sell Products" feature, currently buried)	• Telegram and WhatsApp informal subscription-splitting groups — zero fee, zero trust • Adjacent fintechs (Cred, Jupiter, ET Money) can extend into subscription tracking cheaply • Admin retaliation pattern erodes Net Promoter Score silently — most-upvoted Play Store complaint • RBI scrutiny risk if wallet float grows without clear regulatory positioning

Porter's Five Forces (Marketplace Layer)

- **Buyer power: High.** User switching cost is roughly 5 minutes — no contractual lock-in, no data portability friction, no irreplaceable benefit. Implication: trust is the only durable retention lever.
- **Supplier (admin) power: Concentrated and asymmetric.** Top admins display 1.7K+ ratings; mid-tier admins have under 100. New admins struggle to acquire their first members. Implication: the rating system architecture is the supply-side bottleneck (addressed in Feedback 2).
- **Threat of new entrants: Moderate-to-high.** No regulatory moat, the technical stack is buildable in 6–9 months by a competent team, and the largest moat is brand + trust scaffolding rather than IP. Implication: speed of trust-layer hardening determines defensibility.
- **Substitutes: High.** Telegram and WhatsApp group-sharing of credentials is the primary substitute. Subspace's only structural advantage is the trust layer — which the current rating UI does not adequately deliver.
- **Competitive rivalry: Moderate.** No direct same-category competitor at scale in India yet, but the category is visible to adjacent fintechs. International peers (Spliiit, Together Price) have solved the trust problem with different architectures worth studying.

The five feedback below operationalize the most urgent items from this framework — primarily within the Weaknesses and Threats quadrants.

Feedback 1 — Home Screen Identity Sprawl

Pillar: UX / Features

(a) Observed

On first launch (post-OTP, no transactions yet), the Home tab presents six distinct calls-to-action competing for the new user's attention, in this vertical order:

1. **Events (PREMIUM)** — "Bid to earn exclusive rewards"
2. **Add Subscriptions** — "Track and manage your services"
3. **Sell Products (PREMIUM)** — "Manage & list your vendor products"
4. **Quick Payments** — "Pay bills and recharge instantly"
5. **Add Credit Card** — "Maximize your rewards" (with a large highlighted CTA)
6. **Your Subscriptions** — the actual marketplace entry point

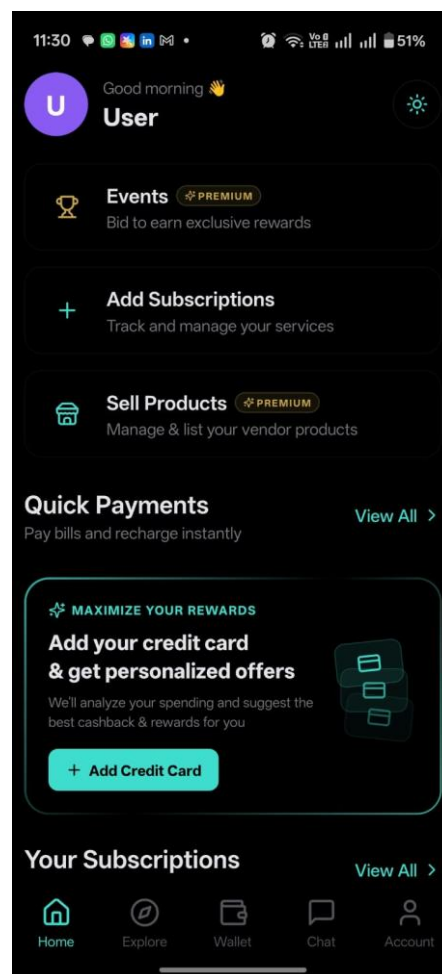


Figure 1.1 — Mobile Home tab: six competing CTAs for a new user

The bottom-nav says the app is for subscription sharing. The Home tab tells a different story — bidding, vendor selling, bill payments, credit card analysis, and tracking are all on equal footing.

(b) Problem

For a new user, this is paralysis. The app's core promise (subscribe-share-save) is invisible above the fold; instead, the first impression is "what is this app actually for?" Two specific business costs follow:

- **D1 retention risk** — the new user has no clear next action that delivers value within their first session. Drop-off after the OTP step is the most expensive drop-off a fintech app can have.
- **Premium feature credibility** — surfacing two "Premium" features (Events, Sell Products) to a user who hasn't transacted once devalues the Premium tier. It looks like upsell, not differentiation.

This pattern aligns with Play Store reviewer Anurag M (19/04/2026, 1★): *"No improvement in UI"* — a vague complaint that becomes specific once you see the home screen.

(c) Ship instead

Replace the six-CTA stack with a single hero unit driven by user state:

- **Day 0 user (no transactions):** one hero card — *"Join your first shared subscription — save up to ₹X this month"* — that opens directly into the Explore tab with the most popular service pre-selected.
- **Returning user with active subscriptions:** the current "Your Subscriptions" view, promoted to the top.
- **Power user (3+ active subscriptions):** surface Events, Sell Products, and Quick Payments contextually under a "More" tab or via a settings drawer.

Tradeoff: This reduces visibility of Premium upsell for new users and may slow Premium tier conversions. Mitigation: surface Premium contextually after the first transaction completes, when value is proven and trust is higher. D1 retention compounds harder than premature upsell.

Feedback 2 — Admin Rating System Has No Signal

Pillar: Features / Trust · *Cross-pillar:* Competitor Analysis

(2) Observed

In the group selection view for any popular subscription (Canva Pro Yearly used here), the rating system shows the following:

- Arani Dutta — 5.0★ (352 reviews), crown badge
- Arjun Kumar — 5.0★ (40 reviews), crown badge
- Yogesh Kumar Saini — 5.0★ (1.79K+ reviews), crown badge
- Tarun Rawat — 4.7★ (1.91K+ reviews), crown badge
- MD Siraj — 5.0★ (625 reviews), crown badge
- Nehit — 4.3★ (53 reviews)

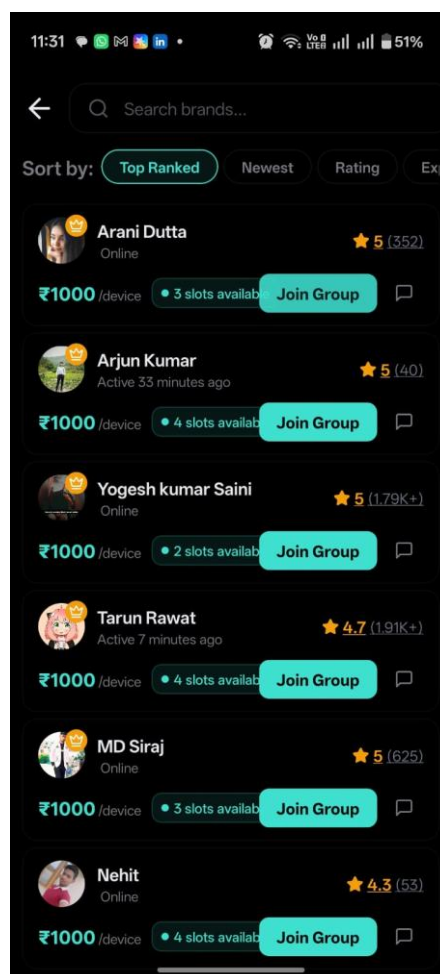


Figure 2.1 — Group selection for Canva Pro Yearly: five of six admins display 5★ + crown

Five of the six top-ranked admins display a 5-star rating and an identical crown badge. The sort dropdown defaults to “Top Ranked” with no visible definition of what that ranking includes. Price is identical (₹1000/device). The only differentiating signal is review count — which favours older admins, not better admins.

(b) Problem

The most-upvoted Play Store complaint about Subspace (10 helpful votes, dated 14/02/2026, reviewer Rohith Ramesh) describes the system failure this design enables:

"An admin removed me from a group because I requested an OTP twice... After I rated that experience 1 star, I unexpectedly received several 1-star ratings and started getting removed from other newly joined groups as well... It seems that some admins prioritize protecting their RATING rather than handling issues in a fair and transparent way."

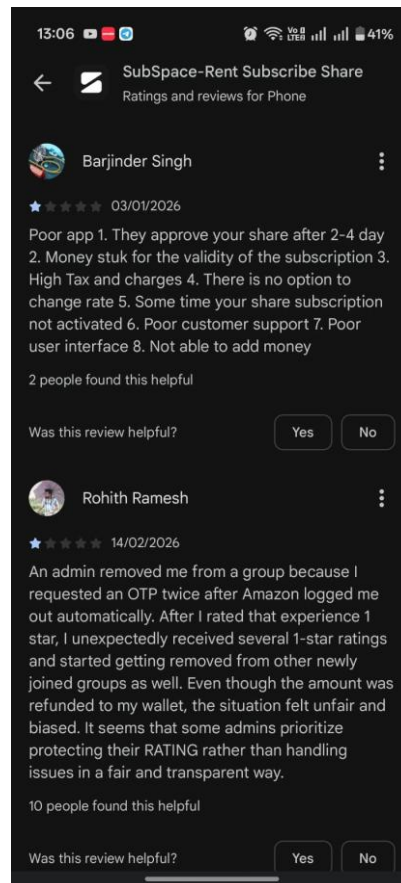


Figure 2.2 — Rohith Ramesh, 14/02/2026, 1 ★ (10 helpful votes — the most-upvoted complaint on Subspace)

Two structural problems are visible here:

- **Rating inflation has erased differentiation.** When 80%+ of admins display the same score, the rating provides zero decision-support to the buyer. Trust signals that don't differentiate are not trust signals — they're decoration.
- **One-sided rating enables retaliation.** Admins can punish complainers by removing them and coordinating retaliatory ratings, which the platform has no mechanism to detect or correct. This isn't a hypothetical — it's the most-validated user complaint on the platform.

For a marketplace built on supply-side trust, this is a foundational issue. The new CEO's stated bet on "AI-native operations" cannot fix trust math that the rating architecture itself is breaking.

Competitor context: Subspace's real competition on the demand side is not other apps — it's informal Telegram and WhatsApp subscription-splitting groups, which charge zero platform fee but provide zero trust scaffolding. Subspace's entire value proposition over Telegram is the trust layer. International peers solve this differently: Spliit (France) uses verified bank-account holders only; Together Price (Italy) escrows the full annual amount and releases monthly to admins. Both architectures structurally prevent the retaliation pattern. Subspace's 5% platform fee is justified *only* if the trust layer is real — today, the rating UI suggests it isn't.

(c) Ship instead

A four-part fix, in order of build complexity:

1. **Two-sided rating.** Admins rate buyers; buyers rate admins. Asymmetric retaliation cancels out because both sides have something to lose.
2. **Time-weighted scoring.** Ratings from the last 30 days carry 3x the weight of ratings older than 90 days. This punishes admins whose service quality has decayed and prevents the "high lifetime average, currently terrible" pattern.
3. **Public dispute count on admin profiles.** Surface "Issues raised: 4 in last 30 days · Resolved: 3 · Avg resolution: 18 hrs" as a hard signal alongside the star rating.
4. **Auto-refund SLA badge.** Admins who complete refunds within 48 hours of a verified issue earn a visible badge. This converts an invisible operational behavior into a competitive signal.

Tradeoff: This makes the marketplace look messier in the short term — average displayed ratings will drop, more disputes will be visible. But the alternative is what Play Store reviews already show: silent churn driven by broken trust. Public messiness is cheaper than silent churn.

Feedback 3 — Refund Logic Is a Black Box at the Moment of Payment

Pillar: Features / Trust

(a) Observed

At checkout for a Canva Pro Yearly group (₹1050 total — ₹1000 item price + ₹50 platform fee), the prominently displayed information notice reads:

"Admin will renew in Aug 03, 2026, else you will receive a partial refund."

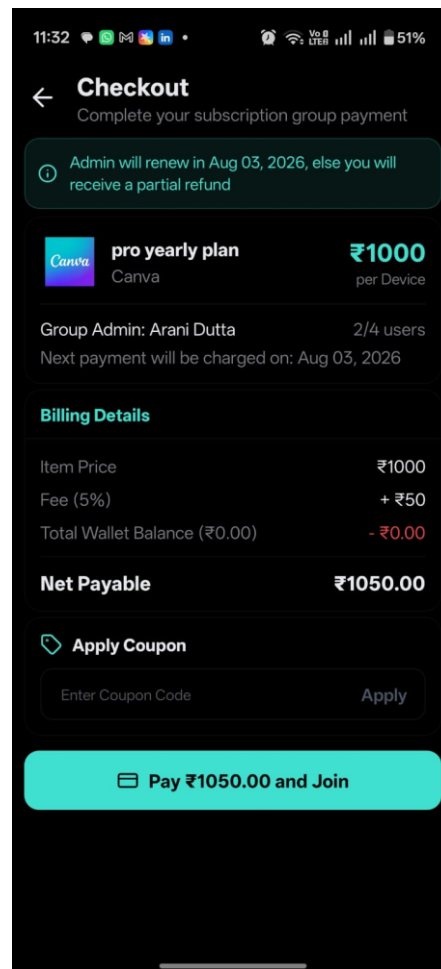


Figure 3.1 — Checkout screen for Canva Pro Yearly: "partial refund" is the entire policy

The word "partial" is the entire refund policy a user sees before clicking "Pay ₹1050.00 and Join." There is no defined formula, no timeline, no example calculation, and no link to a fuller refund policy. The user is being asked to commit ₹1050 against an opaque future-state.

(b) Problem

This is the single most-cited pain pattern across Subspace's negative Play Store reviews. From my reading of recent 1-star reviews, five distinct users describe the same broken refund flow:

- **Rajendra Karmakar (19/05/2026, 1★):** "I bought a gift card worth 1099 rupees for 1012.73 rupees but it got stucked in processing... 3 days I have been nagged at home constantly... still not refunded."
- **RAHUL ROY (10/04/2026, 1★):** "They banned my account. I give them all screenshots that my intention was to login on TV which I can't but still the owner is casual not taking any action."

- **Parminder Singh (19/01/2026, 1★):** "I paid for a subscription through their app and they messaged saying that I'll get the subscription in a day and then 15 days later I still haven't gotten the subscription."
- **Anurag Gupta (06/04/2026, 1★):** "Wallet balance showing in negative after complaint not solve my issue by customer service."
- **Swadhin Das (15/02/2026, 1★):** "Subspace make very bad rule for the user once if you pay then you lose your money... subscription doesn't refund the amount."

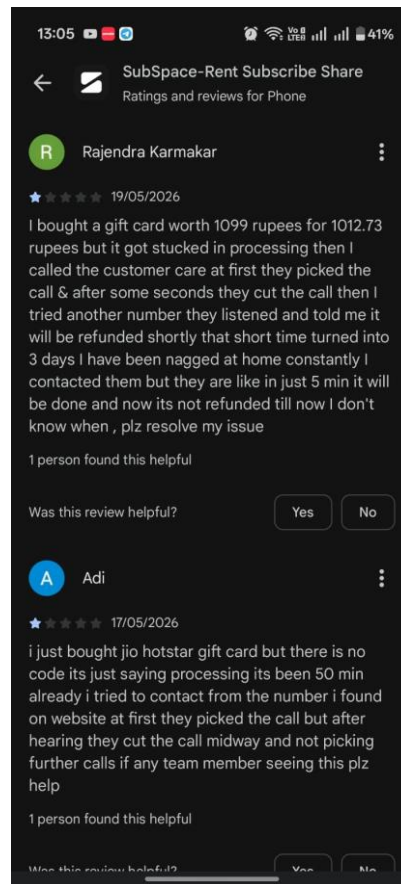


Figure 3.2 — Rajendra Karmakar, 19/05/2026: a representative example of stuck refunds

For a fintech app, opaque refund language at the exact moment of payment violates the first rule of consumer trust: the user must know what they're getting back if things go wrong, before they hand over money.

(c) Ship instead

Three changes to the checkout screen, none of which require new infrastructure — only different copy and a new component:

1. **Pre-purchase refund table.** A simple expandable component on the checkout screen showing: "If admin fails to renew on the renewal date, you receive ₹X back, credited to your wallet within 48 hours." Calculated dynamically based on time remaining. No vague "partial."
2. **Auto-refund to wallet, no ticket needed.** Today, refunds appear to require chasing support. Automate the trigger: if admin doesn't confirm renewal within 72 hours of due date, auto-refund the prorated amount. Cost: predictable platform expense. Benefit: removes the single most-cited friction in the product.
3. **Public refund SLA badge on each group.** Same logic as Feedback 2 — convert silent operational behavior into a competitive signal that admins compete on.

Tradeoff: Auto-refunds expose the platform to potential gaming (e.g., users coordinating to trigger refunds). Mitigations: per-user lifetime refund cap, fraud-detection on rapid refund cycles, admin appeal window before final refund. The platform already absorbs the cost of these failures in churn and 1-star reviews — making the cost explicit and routed is the cheaper path.

Feedback 4 — "Rentals" Is a Marketed Pillar but a Phantom Feature

Pillar: GTM / Positioning · **Cross-pillar:** Potential Collaborations

(a) Observed

Subspace's headline positioning across the Play Store description, the website footer, and the assignment brief itself is consistent:

"Subscriptions · Sharing · Rentals — Subscribe to anything, delivered in minutes."

Three pillars, presented as equal weights. But neither the mobile app nor the web app has a dedicated Rentals tab:

- **Mobile bottom nav (5 items):** Home, Explore, Wallet, Chat, Account
- **Web top nav (5 items):** Home, Explore, Wallet, Chat, Cart

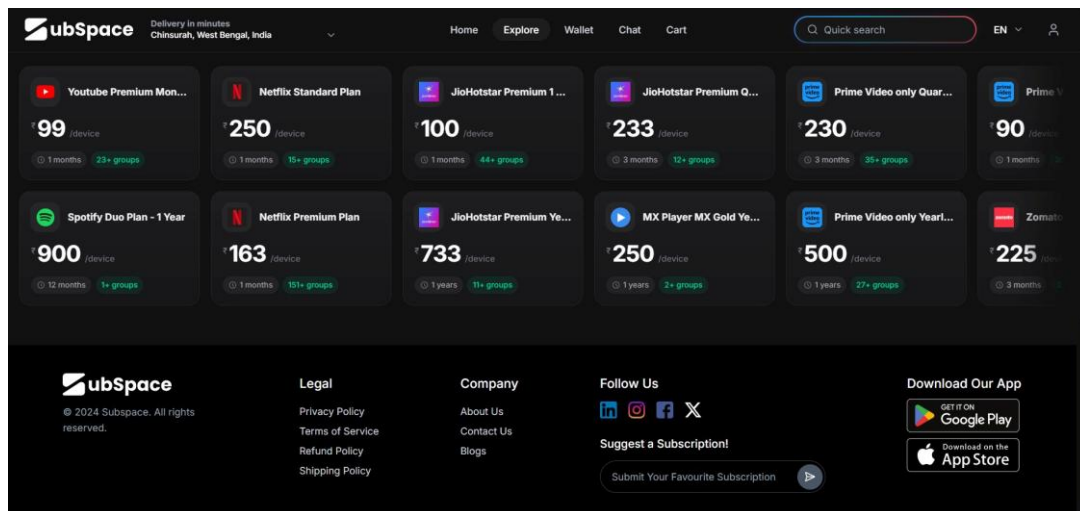


Figure 4.1 — Web top nav: Home, Explore, Wallet, Chat, Cart. No Rentals tab.

Rentals live as a sub-section inside Explore, with no distinct merchandising, no category page, and no surfaced inventory depth. The Account tab does include "Rental History" as a menu item — meaning the company built the infrastructure but didn't promote it to a navigation pillar.

(b) Problem

This is either a revenue leak or a positioning leak — and either is worth fixing.

- **If Rentals is a real revenue line:** It's being suppressed by burial inside Explore. Cross-sell from subscription buyers to rental customers is the single highest-LTV path in a multi-vertical fintech, and the current architecture forecloses it.
- **If Rentals is a strategic experiment that hasn't earned its place:** Keeping it in the headline marketing materials creates a credibility gap. A new user reads the pitch, opens the app, and looks for the third pillar — and doesn't find it. Investors, partners, and the new CEO's narrative all suffer from the same gap.

The cost is low-visibility today but compounding. As the company pivots toward "AI-native consumer fintech" under the new CEO, every claim in headline marketing will be scrutinized harder by both users and partners. Phantom pillars erode that scrutiny.

(c) Ship instead

Decide. There are two clean paths and the middle is the worst option:

1. **Promote Rentals to a top-level navigation pillar.** Dedicated tab in mobile bottom-nav and web top-nav. Category landing page with featured inventory, location-aware availability ("Available in your area / Coming soon"), and bundled offers ("Rent a gaming console + share Game Pass = ₹X/month"). This is the high-investment path that justifies the headline marketing.
2. **Drop Rentals from headline positioning.** Reposition as "India's subscription marketplace" — sharper, easier to communicate, lets the rental flow live quietly as a Phase 2 expansion. This is the path most likely to clarify investor and user messaging immediately, with the lowest engineering cost.

Tradeoff: Option 1 demands real product investment; Option 2 feels like contraction. But the current "claim three pillars, ship two" state is the worst possible signal for a company in CEO transition. Pick one path and commit visibly.

Collaboration angle (if Option 2 is chosen): Rather than building rental inventory and 10-minute logistics in-house, partner with established players — Furlenco for furniture, Rentomojo for appliances and gadgets, RentMacha for short-duration electronics. Offer co-branded subscription bundles ("Rent a PS5 + share PlayStation Plus = ₹X/month all-in"). Subspace contributes the demand-side audience, the partner contributes inventory and last-mile. This converts a phantom pillar into a real but capital-light category, with the partner footing the inventory cost. The same partnership lens applies upstream: bundles with Cred for credit-card rewards on subscriptions, or with Jupiter/Fi for in-app savings goals tied to subscription spend.

Feedback 5 — Marketing Claims Don't Match What's on Screen

Pillar: GTM / Copy

(a) Observed

Three specific mismatches between marketed claims and on-screen reality, captured in a single 5-minute session across mobile and web:

1. **The "92.52% off" Canva carousel on the web home page.** A featured hero banner claims "Canva Plans at 92.52% off." This number is not believable. It almost certainly results from incorrect base-price arithmetic (likely calculating against an MSRP that doesn't reflect Canva's actual annual pricing in India).

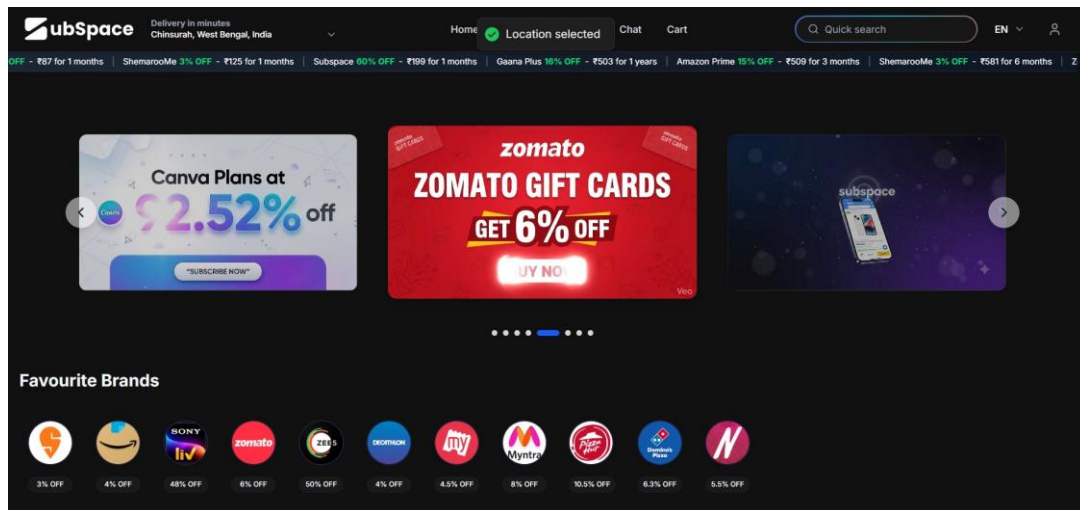


Figure 5.1 — Web home carousel: "92.52% off" — and note the Veo watermark in the corner of the adjacent banner

2. **The "up to 80% off" Play Store marketing claim vs. the home screen reality.** The Play Store description promises "Up to 80% off on Netflix Premium, Amazon Prime, YouTube Premium..." The mobile Explore screen shows actual hero discounts as: Swiggy 3%, Amazon 4%, Zomato 6%, Sony Liv 48% (outlier). The headline hero card on home is "Play Store Gift Cards 3% off."



Figure 5.2 — Mobile Explore: headline hero is "Play Store Gift Cards 3% OFF". Favourite brand discounts: 3%, 4%, 48%, 6%

1. **The "© 2024 Subspace. All rights reserved" footer on the web app.** The current date is 31 May 2026.

A separate detail worth noting: one of the hero carousels uses an AI-generated visual that still carries the Veo watermark in the corner — a small but visible production gap for a company positioning itself as AI-native.

(b) Problem

Individually, each of these is small. Cumulatively, they signal that no one is editing the home page with a discerning eye. For a fintech app where the user is being asked to commit money to strangers via the platform, basic numerical and copy hygiene is a trust prerequisite — not a polish nice-to-have.

There is also a direct funnel cost. A new user lands on the home screen, sees "Play Store Gift Cards 3% off" as the hero offer, and forms an impression of what "discount" means on this platform. The 48% Sony Liv offer — which is genuinely strong — is buried two scrolls below. The marketing copy and the merchandising decisions are working against each other.

(c) Ship instead

Three quick fixes and one process fix:

1. **Discount math sanity check before any banner ships.** Automated test: if a displayed discount exceeds 80%, flag for human review before publication. Catches the 92.52% class of errors at zero ongoing cost.
2. **Replace the headline 3% Play Store hero with the highest believable offer.** Currently 48% Sony Liv. Anchoring the user's first impression on the strongest real offer (not the safest small one) costs nothing and lifts perceived value.
3. **Update the copyright year.** Calendar reminder, January 1, every year. Trivial.
4. **Remove the Veo watermark from any AI-generated marketing creative.** If the company is genuinely AI-native, the production polish should match the positioning.

Tradeoff: Highlighting larger discounts as hero offers increases user expectations and may surface complaints when smaller categories deliver less. Mitigation: pair the hero with a clear "starting at" disclaimer.

Prioritization & Closing

If forced to ship only two of these in the next sprint, I would ship Feedback 3 (Refund Black Box) and Feedback 2 (Admin Rating System), in that order.

Why these two first

- They are the only two feedbacks backed by direct, repeated, recent user voice on Play Store. Five-plus users in 2026 alone have raised these exact issues, with the single most-upvoted complaint (10 helpful votes) being a direct consequence of the rating architecture.
- Both are foundational trust math. The other three feedbacks (home sprawl, phantom pillars, marketing-copy hygiene) are growth-stage problems. Trust math is a survival problem for a two-sided marketplace.
- Both are buildable in a single sprint with the existing tech stack. The refund table and auto-refund logic are pricing and timing rules; the two-sided rating is a database schema change plus a UI surface. Neither needs new AI infrastructure.

The remaining three (Feedbacks 1, 4, 5) cluster well into a second sprint focused on positioning and first-session experience.

One closing note

The strongest signal I encountered in three days of using this product was not in the app — it was watching founder Joey Dash personally reply to negative Play Store reviews from April 2026 onward. The will to fix things is visibly present at the founder level. The gap is in operationalizing that will into product decisions before users have to write a 1-star review to be heard. Every one of the five feedbacks above is an instance of that gap.

— End of report —